

BEFORE



The Catholic Church dominated Europe throughout the medieval period and into the 16th century.

EARLY REFORMERS

The Lollards from England in the 14th century and the Hussites from Bohemia in the early 15th century both

HUSSITES

proposed reforms of the Catholic Church to end corruption and purify church doctrine.

THE GREAT SCHISM

Pope Clement V moved the papacy to Avignon in France in 1309 to avoid internal feuding in Rome. An attempt to return the papacy to Rome in 1379 led to the election of two rival popes, causing a schism <<194–95. A Church meeting in Germany in 1417 elected a third pope to replace the two rivals.

RENAISSANCE EXCESS

The building of a vast new basilica in Rome was funded by the sale of indulgences, or pardons for sins, which typified the extravagance of the Catholic Church in the 15th century.



ST. PETER'S BASILICA, ROME

120 The number of years it took to build St. Peter's Basilica in Rome. Pope Leo X financed construction partly through the sale of indulgences and used the leading artists of the Renaissance (see pp.250–53) to design and decorate it.

The Reformation

A simple but effective protest against corruption in the Catholic Church in 1517 soon turned into a major force for religious change known as the Reformation. It transformed the political, social, and economic face of Europe over the next few centuries, and its legacy can still be seen around the world today.

Martin Luther's (see below) challenge against the Catholic Church in Wittenberg, Saxony, came after the arrival in the area of German preacher Johann Tetzel, who was selling indulgences (see BEFORE) to raise money for Pope Leo X. Indulgences had long been criticized by Catholic theologians (scholars of religion) but their financial success ensured the practice was too lucrative to end. Luther's response, on October 23, 1517, was to post a document bearing 95 theses (statements) on the door of the town church. Luther's theses were not radical, but they attracted a wide audience, and due to recent advances in printing methods (see p.253) they were widely distributed and read. Luther's initial criticism of the church focused on the sale of indulgences, but he went on to attack the core Catholic teachings of transubstantiation (the belief that bread and wine change into the body and blood of Christ when received during communion), clerical celibacy, and papal supremacy. He also called for a reform of religious orders such as monasteries, and a return to the simplicity of the earlier church.

The Lutheran church

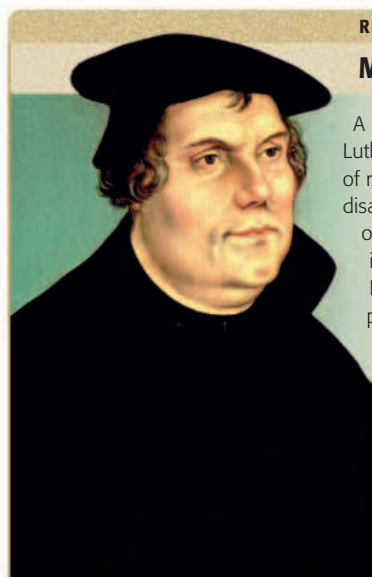
Luther's challenge to the established church won him many followers, but he initially wished only to reform the existing church rather than set up an entirely new system. Several attempts were made to reconcile Luther with the religious authorities, until, in 1521, he



Leather bindings enclose parchment pages. About 170 copies of the Bible were printed, its 1,200 pages appearing in two separate volumes.

The Gutenberg Bible

The world's first printed Bible was produced, in Latin, by the German printer Johannes Gutenberg in 1455. Bibles in the vernacular, or common language, first appeared during the Reformation.



RELIGIOUS REFORMER (1483–1546)

MARTIN LUTHER

A university-educated priest and friar, Martin Luther became a professor of theology (the study of religion) at Wittenberg University in 1512. His disagreements with the Catholic Church hierarchy over its conduct led to a revolt against the institution in 1517 that soon spread across Europe. Luther was a reluctant revolutionary, preferring at first to reform the Church from within, but once excluded from the Church in 1521, he proved to be an energetic and skilled leader, making good use of the new printing technology to write and distribute pamphlets publicizing his views. His belief in order, and his conservative political views, put him at odds with many who wished to develop more radical religious doctrines.

“Here I stand. I can do no other. **God help me.** Amen.”

MARTIN LUTHER, ADDRESSING THE DIET OF WORMS, APRIL 18, 1521